emphasized ‘one rank one pension’ with all the force at our command. When we meet these old warriors at reunions, they appear to have aged prematurely, although their spirit remains undiminished. We as leaders need to help them achieve financial security while in service. It is a matter of pride that we have been able to create viable and self-sustaining institutions serving the cause of serving and retired personnel and their dependents, as also for war widows.

I have strong views on the system of giving honours and awards. First and foremost, recognition must be given for acts of gallantry in a fair and unbiased manner and as close to the date of the action as possible. To arrest the trend of an unhealthy race for awards by showing more ‘kills’, I banned the use of that word on becoming the chief. I declared that commanders and units would be judged by their overall performance and not just by the number of terrorists killed. We could not afford any more cases such as the one of fake killings videofilmed in Siachen. Besides, it is my view that ‘yudh seva’ (distinguished service for war) medals should be given only in exceptional cases in peace time. Even during the Kargil war, I could not reconcile myself to the fact that some senior officers were given the ‘yudh seva’ series of awards when most of the others in the same headquarters were awarded distinguished peace service awards. Indiscretion and double standards of this kind lower the sanctity of the awards. No system can be foolproof, yet it should be our endeavour to see that deserving cases get honoured appropriately and at the right time. Furthermore, I strongly recommend introducing a system where a ‘sena’, ‘nau sena’ or ‘vayu sena’ medal (equivalent of a military cross) could be pinned on the spot in the field by the chiefs. There can be nothing more inspiring or motivating for the officers and men. The government needs to look into this important factor and, if required, guidelines could be spelt out for this step.

‘The army marches on its stomach’ is a famous saying. Therefore, the quality of rations supplied to our officers and men was an important issue for me. I was encouraged by the caring attitude and interest shown by Defence Minister A.K. Antony, who often